



PES UNIVERSITY, BANGALORE
Department of Computer Science and Engineering

Software Architecture & Design Specification (SAD)

AttendEase – Student Attendance Management System Team 3 | Course UE24CS341A | PES University

Revision History

Version	Date	Description	Author(s)
1.0	03 October 2026	Initial SAD covering architecture and design for AttendEase.	Team 3

Approvals

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1. Introduction

1.1 Purpose

This Software Architecture & Design Specification (SAD) describes the system architecture and detailed design of AttendEase, a web-based Student Attendance Management System. It translates the functional and non-functional requirements captured in the AttendEase Software Requirements Specification (SRS) into an architectural structure, component design, and interaction design that the development team will implement. This document is intended to guide implementation, support code review, and serve as a reference for testing and maintenance.

1.2 Scope

This SAD covers the architecture of the AttendEase web application, including its layered component structure, the technology stack, the chosen architectural pattern, security architecture, and the detailed design of two representative workflows (attendance marking and correction-request approval) via UML sequence diagrams. It also documents the REST API design, error-handling strategy, and traceability between architectural components and the requirements defined in the SRS.

1.3 Intended Audience

- Team 3 developers implementing AttendEase modules.
- Course instructor and evaluators assessing the Level 3 mini-project.
- Future maintainers extending or reviewing the system.

1.4 Definitions, Acronyms and Abbreviations

Term	Definition
SAD	Software Architecture & Design Specification
SRS	Software Requirements Specification
DRF	Django REST Framework
ORM	Object-Relational Mapping
STRIDE	Spoofing, Tampering, Repudiation, Information disclosure, Denial of service, Elevation of privilege — a threat-modelling framework
JWT	JSON Web Token, used for stateless session authentication
RBAC	Role-Based Access Control

2. Document Overview

2.1 How to Use This Document

Section 3 (Architecture) should be read first by anyone evaluating the overall system structure, technology choices, and security posture. Section 4 (Design) should be read by developers implementing or reviewing specific modules, as it drills down into sequence-level interactions and the API contract. The Appendices provide supporting glossary, references, and tooling information.

2.2 Related Documents

- AttendEase Software Requirements Specification (SRS), v1.1, Team 3.
- AttendEase Project Synopsis, Team 3.

- AttendEase Software Test Plan (STP), Team 3.
- PES University SE Level 3 Mini-Project Guidelines and Deliverables Checklist.

3. Architecture

3.1 Goals and Constraints

Architectural goals:

- Clear separation of concerns between presentation, API, business logic, and data access, so that each of the four team-owned roles can develop and test their module independently.
- Maintainability and readability, given the project's academic timeline and four-person team.
- Security by design for authentication, role-based access, and sensitive attendance data.
- Testability — each service is unit-testable in isolation from the HTTP layer.

Constraints:

- Must be implemented in Python/Django within a single academic semester by a 4-member team.
- Must use Git/GitHub with a CI/CD pipeline (GitHub Actions) and Jira/GitHub Projects for sprint tracking, per course guidelines.
- Must run on commodity/free-tier hosting suitable for a student project (e.g., containerized deployment via Docker).

3.2 Stakeholders and Concerns

Stakeholder	Primary Concern
Students	Fast, accurate view of personal attendance; easy correction requests.
Faculty	Quick, reliable attendance marking; simple approval workflow for corrections.
Administrators	Accurate academic setup (courses, sections, faculty mapping); reliable reports.
Development Team (Team 3)	A modular design that maps cleanly onto the 4 owned roles and allows parallel development.
Course Evaluators	Clear, traceable architecture and design that satisfies IEEE-style documentation expectations.

3.3 Component (UML) Diagram

The diagram below shows AttendEase's layered component architecture: the Presentation Layer (role-specific web UIs), the API/Controller Layer (Django REST Framework endpoints), the Business Logic Layer (services, grouped by the four team-owned roles), the Data Access Layer (repositories over the Django ORM), the PostgreSQL database, and the external SMTP email service used for correction-request notifications.

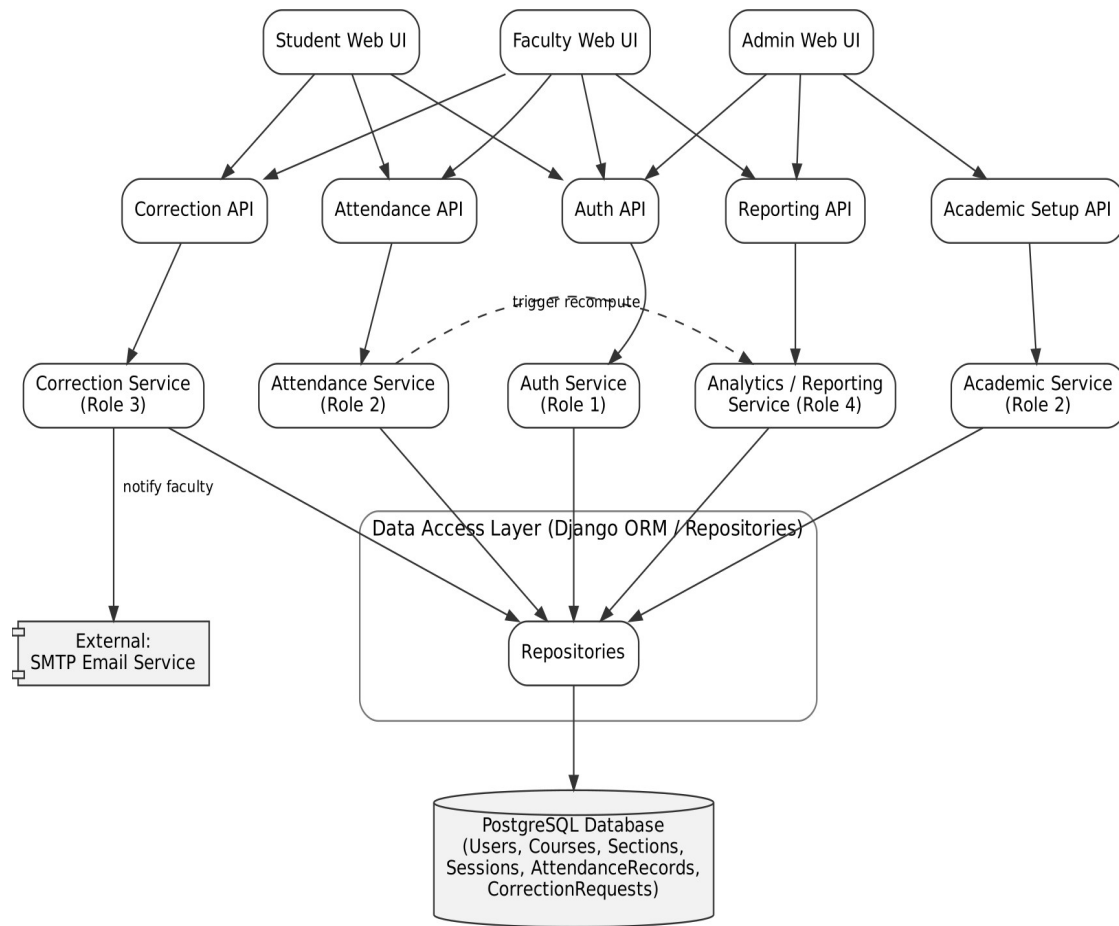


Figure 1: AttendEase component architecture (layered view).

3.4 Component Descriptions

Component	Responsibility
Student / Faculty / Admin Web UI	Role-specific browser-rendered views (Django templates / Bootstrap 5) that collect input and render data returned by the API layer.
Auth API & Auth Service	Registration, login, JWT/session issuance, and role-based access control (Role 1).
Academic Setup API & Academic Service	Course, section, and timetable management; faculty-to-section assignment (Role 2).
Attendance API & Attendance Service	Attendance session creation and per-student attendance recording (Role 2).
Correction API & Correction Service	Raising, listing, and approving/rejecting attendance correction requests (Role 3).
Reporting API & Analytics/Reporting Service	Attendance-shortage identification and report generation (Role 4).
Repositories (Data Access Layer)	Encapsulates all Django ORM queries, isolating business services from persistence details.
PostgreSQL Database	Durable storage for users, courses, sections, sessions, attendance records, and correction requests.
SMTP Email Service (external)	Sends correction-request notification emails to faculty.

3.5 Chosen Architecture Pattern and Rationale

AttendEase adopts a Layered (N-tier) architecture — Presentation, API/Controller, Business Logic (Service), and Data Access layers — implemented on top of Django and Django REST Framework.

Rationale:

- The layered pattern maps directly onto Django's own MVT conventions, minimizing framework friction for a student team.
- Each of the four team-owned roles (User Access & Student Portal; Academic & Attendance Setup; Attendance Updates & Corrections; Attendance Analytics & Reporting) corresponds to one vertical slice of API + Service, allowing the team to work largely in parallel with limited merge conflicts.
- A microservices architecture was considered and rejected: the added operational complexity (service discovery, inter-service networking, distributed transactions) is not justified for a single-database, single-deployment, academic-scale system with a 4-person team and a one-semester timeline.
- The Service layer isolates business rules (e.g., duplicate-attendance validation, shortage thresholds) from both the HTTP layer and the ORM, keeping logic unit-testable.

3.6 Technology Stack and Data Stores

Layer	Technology
Backend framework	Python 3.11, Django 4.x, Django REST Framework
Frontend	Django Templates, Bootstrap 5, vanilla JavaScript
Database	PostgreSQL 14+
Authentication	Django's auth system + JWT (djanoestframework-simplejwt) for API sessions
CI/CD	GitHub Actions (lint, test, build on every pull request)
Containerization	Docker, docker-compose for local/staging environments
Project tracking	Jira / GitHub Projects (Kanban board, linked issues and PRs)
Email	SMTP (Django email backend) for correction-request notifications

3.7 Risks and Mitigations

Risk	Mitigation
Concurrent attendance edits by faculty causing data races	Database-level unique constraints on (session, student); service-layer validation before insert/update.
Scope creep given the 4-role split and semester timeline	Sprint-based plan of work with weekly Jira/GitHub Projects tracking and fixed sprint boundaries.
Team members unfamiliar with Django REST Framework	Shared code-review checklist and pairing during early sprints (Role: API integration & code review).
Loss of uncommitted work / merge conflicts	Mandatory feature-branch workflow with pull requests and CI checks before merge.
Sensitive attendance data exposure	Role-based access control and HTTPS-only deployment (see Section 3.9).

3.8 Traceability to Requirements

The table below maps architectural components to the functional requirement groups they implement, as defined in the AttendEase SRS Section 5.

Component	SRS Requirement IDs
Auth API / Auth Service	FR-001–FR-005, FR-034, SEC-001–SEC-006
Academic Setup API / Academic Service	FR-006–FR-013
Attendance API / Attendance Service	FR-014–FR-019, FR-037, FR-038
Correction API / Correction Service	FR-024–FR-028
Reporting API / Analytics Service	FR-029–FR-033, FR-035, FR-036
Student/Faculty/Admin Web UI	FR-020–FR-023 and the presentation aspects of all FRs above

3.9 Security Architecture

Security architecture is derived using a lightweight STRIDE threat-modelling pass over the system's trust boundaries (browser ↔ API, API ↔ database, API ↔ SMTP).

STRIDE Category	Representative Threat	Architectural Mitigation
Spoofing	An attacker impersonates a faculty or admin account.	Password hashing (PBKDF2/bcrypt via Django), JWT-based session tokens, optional login throttling.
Tampering	A student modifies attendance data directly via API manipulation.	Server-side role-based authorization checks on every write endpoint; DB-level constraints.
Repudiation	A faculty member denies having approved/rejected a correction request.	Audit fields (acted_by, acted_at) stored on every CorrectionRequest; immutable status-change log.
Information Disclosure	Attendance records of one section leak to unauthorized students.	Query-level scoping by authenticated user's role and enrolled sections; HTTPS in transit.
Denial of Service	Bulk/automated requests overwhelm the attendance-marking endpoint.	Rate limiting at the API gateway/reverse proxy layer; pagination on list endpoints.
Elevation of Privilege	A student account attempts to call admin-only academic-setup endpoints.	DRF permission classes enforcing RBAC per endpoint, verified in Section 6.3 (Security Objectives/Requirements) of the SRS.

4. Design

4.1 Design Overview

This section details two representative end-to-end workflows at the sequence level, the REST API contract, and cross-cutting design concerns (error handling, logging, UX). The two workflows were chosen because they represent the system's core write-paths and both faculty- and student-facing interactions: (1) Faculty starts a session and marks attendance, and (2) a student raises a correction request which a faculty member subsequently approves.

4.2 UML Sequence Diagrams

4.2.1 Sequence Diagram 1 — Faculty Starts Session & Marks Attendance

Traces to FR-014 through FR-019 (Attendance Recording) and FR-037/FR-038 (Attendance Management).

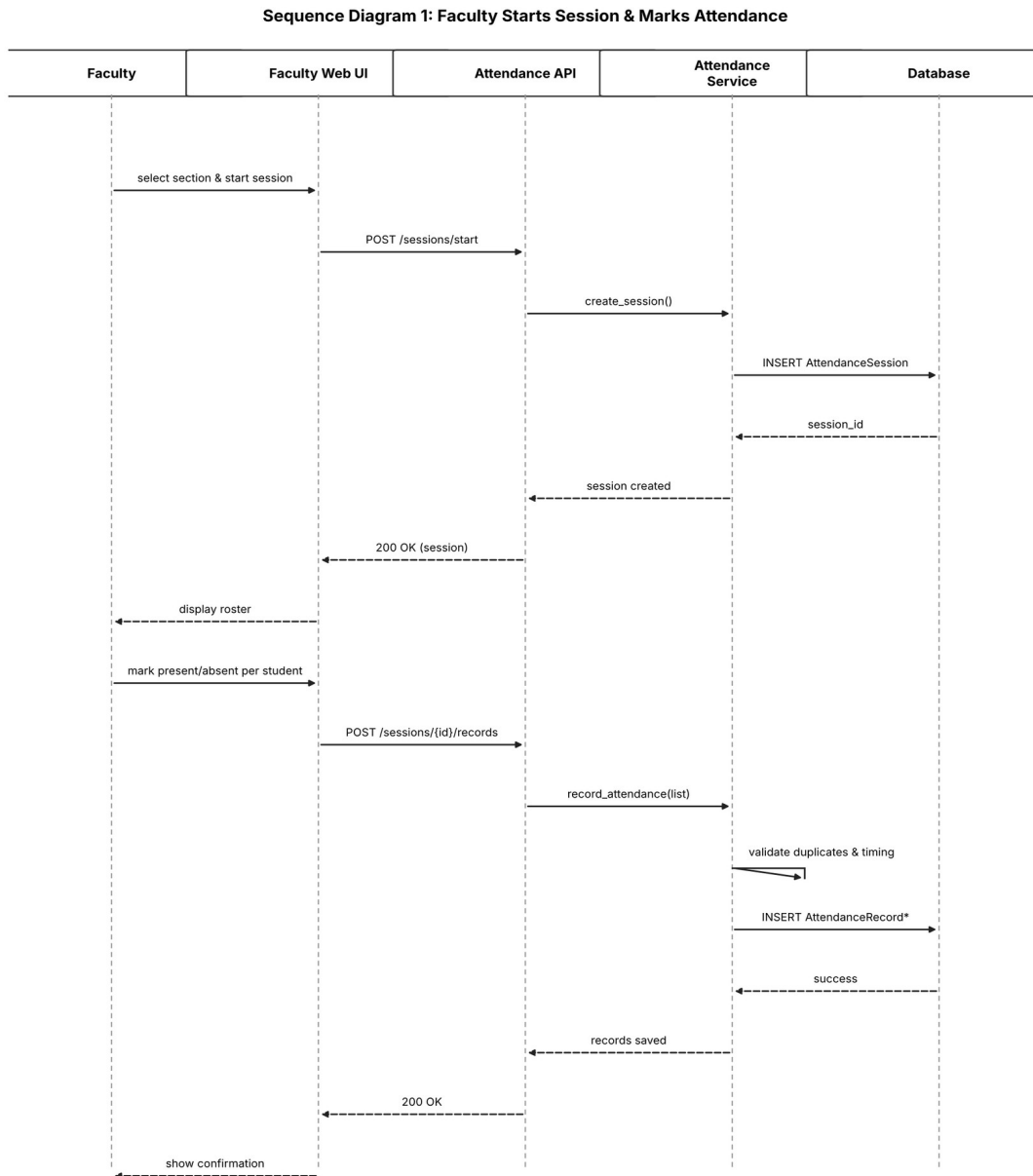


Figure 2: Faculty starts an attendance session and marks student attendance.

4.2.2 Sequence Diagram 2 — Student Raises Correction Request & Faculty Approves

Traces to FR-024 through FR-028 (Attendance Correction Requests).

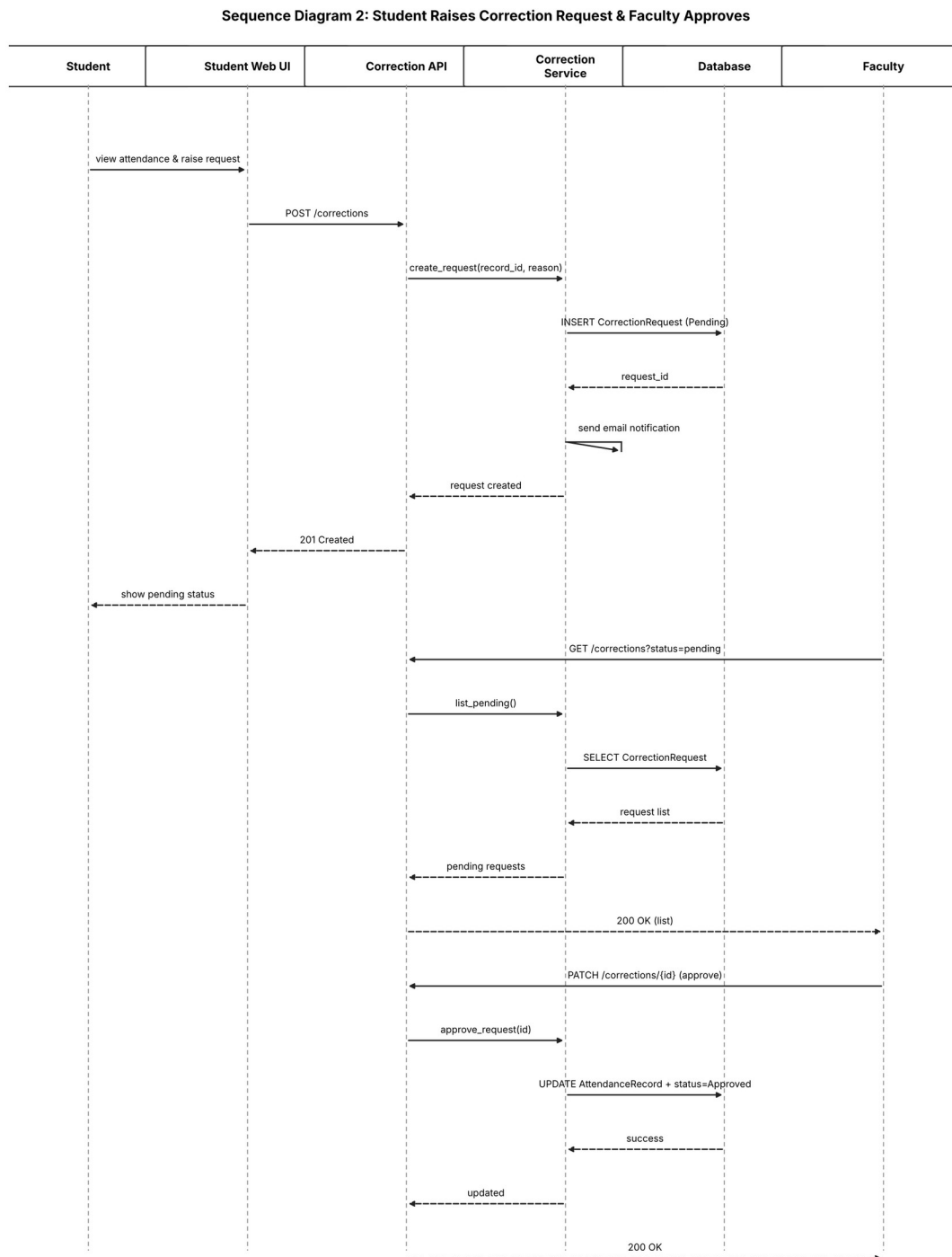


Figure 3: Student raises a correction request; faculty reviews and approves it.

4.3 API Design

Representative REST endpoints exposed by the API/Controller layer (full contract to be maintained in the project's OpenAPI/Swagger specification during implementation):

Method & Path	Description	Auth / Role
POST /api/auth/register	Register a new user (student/faculty).	Public (admin approval for faculty)

Method & Path	Description	Auth / Role
POST /api/auth/login	Authenticate and issue JWT.	Public
GET /api/academic/courses	List courses and sections.	Authenticated
POST /api/academic/assignments	Assign faculty to a course-section.	Admin
POST /api/attendance/sessions/start	Start a new attendance session for a section.	Faculty
POST /api/attendance/sessions/{id}/records	Submit attendance records for a session.	Faculty
GET /api/attendance/dashboard	Retrieve a student's attendance summary.	Student
POST /api/corrections	Raise an attendance correction request.	Student
PATCH /api/corrections/{id}	Approve or reject a correction request.	Faculty
GET /api/reports/defaulters	Generate attendance-shortage/defaulters report.	Faculty/Admin

4.4 Error Handling, Logging and Monitoring

- All API errors return a consistent JSON envelope: {"error_code", "message", "details"} with appropriate HTTP status codes (400/401/403/404/409/500).
- Validation errors (e.g., duplicate attendance marking) are raised as 409 Conflict with a descriptive error_code so the frontend can show a precise message.
- Server-side exceptions are logged centrally (Python logging module → rotating file handler in development, structured JSON logs in production) with request correlation IDs.
- Critical failures (e.g., failed email notification on correction request) are retried once and logged as warnings rather than failing the parent request.
- CI pipeline runs automated tests on every pull request; failures block merge (see Test Plan, Section 5).

4.5 UX Design

- Student dashboard: single-page summary of attendance percentage per course, with a shortage warning banner when below the configured threshold.
- Faculty attendance-marking screen: roster-style checklist with bulk "mark all present" and per-student toggle, optimized for marking a full section in under two minutes.
- Correction-request flow: students submit a reason via a short form; faculty see a single pending-requests queue with one-click approve/reject.
- Consistent Bootstrap 5 component library across all three role-specific UIs for visual consistency and reduced frontend effort (owned by the UI/UX & frontend support secondary responsibility).

4.6 Open Issues and Next Steps

- Finalize whether push/email notifications for correction-request status changes are in scope for the current semester or deferred.
- Decide on exact attendance-shortage threshold (e.g., 75%) and whether it is globally configured or per-course.
- Confirm production hosting target (e.g., free-tier PaaS) before the final deployment sprint.

5. Appendices

5.1 Glossary

Term	Definition
Attendance Session	A single faculty-initiated instance of attendance-taking for one course-section on one date/period.
Defaulter	A student whose attendance percentage falls below the configured shortage threshold.
Correction Request	A student-raised request to amend an attendance record, subject to faculty approval.

5.2 References

- ISO/IEC/IEEE 42010:2011 — Systems and software engineering — Architecture description.
- OWASP Top 10 (2021) — Web Application Security Risks.
- NIST SP 800-160 — Systems Security Engineering.
- AttendEase Software Requirements Specification (SRS), v1.1, Team 3.

5.3 Tools

- Graphviz — component/architecture diagram generation.
- Matplotlib (Python) — UML sequence diagram generation.
- draw.io / Swagger (planned) — ongoing diagram and API-contract maintenance during implementation.